THE COMPREHENSIVE GUIDE TO LEVANTINE ARABIC

الـدَّلـيـل الـشّـامِل للعَرَبيَّة الشّاميَّة

This book provides a framework for building your proficiency at the Beginner and intermediate Levels in Levantine Arabic in the following areas: reading, writing, listening, and speaking.

Mohammad K. Ayaseh

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Deewan Institute
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Inquiries can be directed to:

Mohammad K. Ayaseh
mohammad.k.ayaseh@gmail.com

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First and foremost, I would like to thank all of my Arabic language students and friends for trusting me and believing in me as their teacher. They have inspired and motivated me to improve my knowledge and to write this book.

Thanks to Duaa Allan for all of the early mornings and late nights whilst we created Deewan together. I also want to thank my wonderful team at Deewan for their contributions to this book.

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Thanks to my family for their patience whilst I sacrificed my time with them to tackle this labour of love, and especially my mother, who has taken the brunt of that sacrifice. I owe all of my accomplishments to her.

Sincerely,

Mohammad K. Ayaseh

Introduction

The Levant Area, also called Bilad Al-Sham, is the eastern coastal strip of the Mediterranean Sea and consists of Jordan, Palestine, Syria, and Lebanon. Levantine Arabic is considered the dialect that most resembles Modern Standard Arabic (MSA), and is one of the five major Arabic dialects, with over 50 million native speakers.

Although Levantine Arabic is used colloquially for daily conversations in the Levant, the currently available curriculum books focus on MSA rather than actual spoken dialect. To the best of my knowledge, this book is the first of its kind as it covers the fundamentals of Levantine Arabic.

This book is a culmination of my experience teaching MSA and Levantine Arabic to hundreds of students from all around the world. It is the result of my efforts to meet the essential linguistic needs of Arabic language students, and for them to build a strong base in the spoken dialect.

One of the essential goals when writing this book was to simplify and solidify the way language instruction is provided to non-native speakers. Therefore, this book utilizes a technique that we use at Deewan Institute called *The Ladder of Words*. Each lesson builds on the vocabulary and structures from prior lessons. Students build familiarity with the words and become progressively aware of the patterns and structures in the Arabic language as they practice reading, writing, listening, and speaking.

I have aimed to make this book user-friendly, with or without a teacher. Each lesson starts with clearly stated goals, followed by structured lessons, supplementary exercises, and recorded readings. Each lesson ends with a checklist for students (and teachers) to monitor their progress.

The Comprehensive Guide to Levantine Arabic is not intended only for Beginner Level students, but also to fill the gaps for any Arabic student at any level. It is my hope that this book facilitates both the acquisition and reinforcement of the Levantine Arabic language for students of all levels.

How to use this book

This book is specifically designed for those learning Arabic for the first time, however, it may also provide some new insights into the Arabic language for pre-intermediate and intermediate students. The chapters progress from Beginner Low, to Mid, and finally Beginner High, as can be seen on *The Table of Contents* page. Regardless of your position within this scale, we recommend you work through the whole book as there are different aspects throughout the book that will benefit students at any Beginner Level, as well as higher level students.

An overview is provided on the first page of each lesson giving details of the topics covered within the lesson. Refer to these when looking for specific topics within the book.

Use the illustrations provided in *The Writing Guidance* table on pages 4 to 7 to help you memorise the alphabet. You can even create your own illustrations to help with memorisation.

Look out for the 🔊 symbol which denotes that there is an audio file available for that section, and use the audio files located on the website to help improve your listening, pronunciation and Arabic in general. The website address and QR code, as well as the password required to access the audio files are provided on the first page of each lesson.

Figure 1 on page 8 helps you with the pronunciation of the letters and shows you the letter exits (where the sound of the letter originates within the mouth or throat).

A list of new words is provided at the end of most lessons in a *Ladder of Words*. Put all the new words in the lessons, from the *Ladder of Words* or elsewhere, onto flashcards so you can use them to help you memorise the words before moving on to the next lesson. This can be done on paper cards or using a digital app. There are a wide variety of apps for this, which you can find on any app store, some of which are highlighted in the resources section on our website. We recommend trying a few different apps before storing a large number of words in order to find which one is right for you.

Whilst listening to the audio recordings of the vocab provided in this book, why not test yourself by trying to guess the Arabic equivalents of the English words before they are uttered?

Always do the exercises provided as they will help towards improving your level, and, where possible, ask your teacher to correct your work. We recommend being diligent in completing the comprehension exercises and using them, and all the language you have learnt, regularly, in your daily life.

A *Self-Check* is given at the end of each lesson to help students understand what they have learnt and what they still need to work on. Be reflective and honest with yourself when filling in the *Self-Check* so you know what you need to improve on to enhance your level.

If you want to really benefit from this book, it is important to write and record your own conversations using the vocabulary from each lesson, and to ask your teacher or a friend to practise them with you, as instructed within the comprehension exercises.

At the end of the book, a glossary of words is provided. This can be used to revise and memorise vocabulary taught within the lessons, and we recommend creating your own glossaries either in a word document or within a flashcard app, so you can keep adding to them and writing example sentences for these words, verbs and daily expressions.

How to improve your Arabic

Vocalising your Arabic is an important part of learning the language. Make sure, when listening to the audio, that you repeat what you hear, pausing as required, and also say the words while the audio is playing to ensure your pronunciation is correct. It is always a good idea to record yourself and listen back so you can compare it to the audio and check your pronunciation.

In order to improve your understanding of different Arabic words, and to help with memorisation, make connections between words, for example: find synonyms of words along with their antonyms and try to use them in different contexts. Always write them down and store them with your learnt vocabulary.

Another great way to improve your Arabic is to write simple sentences, conversations and stories in your own language; then replace the words in the texts with their Arabic equivalent, once you have learnt them, in order to help you practise using the Arabic words you have learnt. Over time of learning more and more Arabic, keep adding more Arabic words to the same sentences, conversations and stories until the whole text turns to Arabic. In this way, you make sure you are practising the words and expressions you learn from the book as you learn them. This helps a great deal with memorisation.

Further learning can be done by using the texts given in the book. The words from these texts can be replaced with synonyms or antonyms, in order to broaden your Arabic vocabulary and enhance your Arabic language.

SCAN ME

AUDIO FILES

Chapter 1

- **Lesson 1** – The Alphabet
- **Lesson 2** – Vowels, Sukoon and Shaddeh
- **Lesson 3** – The Sun and Moon Letters
- **Lesson 4** – The Hamzeh

SCAN ME

To access the audio files for this chapter, scan the QR code.
This will take you to a OneDrive folder where you can download the audio files directly.
If you experience any issues, please contact:
management@deewaninstitute.com

Lesson 1

The Alphabet

In this lesson you will learn:

A) The alphabet and how to read it. Section 1.1

B) How to use Deewan Institute's memorisation techniques to associate letters with pictures and sounds. Section 1.1

C) How to pronounce and locate the vocal positions of each letter. Section 1.2

D) How to write letters within words including each letter's beginning, middle, and end forms. Section 1.3

E) How to build your vocabulary using the "Ladder of Words" for Lesson 1. Section 1.4

To access the audio files for this lesson, scan the QR code.
This will take you to a YouTube channel where you can listen to the audio files directly.

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SCAN ME

Section 1.1

مُقَدِّمة للحُروف العَرَبِيّة
Introduction to the Arabic Alphabet

خ	ح	ج	ث	ت	ب	ا
ص	ش	س	ز	ر	ذ	د
ق	ف	غ	ع	ظ	ط	ض
ي	و	ه	ن	م	ل	ك

The Arabic alphabet consists of 28 letters. When words are written, they are written from right to left, and the letters connect like cursive English. Each letter can be connected from the right, and all except 6 can be connected to the left. Unlike English, Arabic has no capitalisation.

Follow the instructions below for Deewan Institute's memorisation techniques:

1. Use the visual hints (the shape of the letter associated with its sound) to help you memorise the letters.

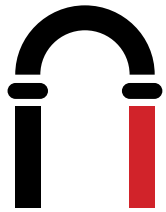
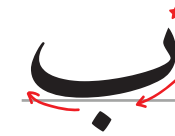
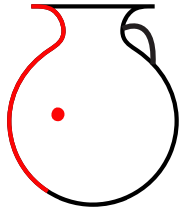
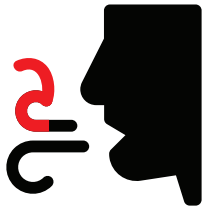
2. Start at the position of the star ★ when writing the letters.

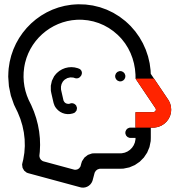
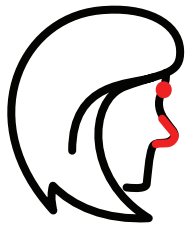
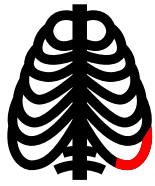
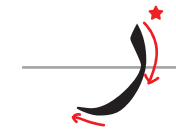
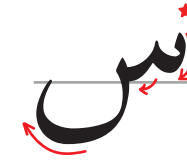
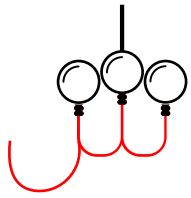
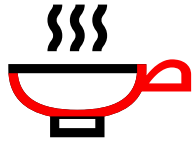
3. Focus on the letters in *red* when you read or listen 🔊 to the pronunciation examples of the English words in the second column.

4. Read and write from the right side of the page, as Arabic is written from right to left.

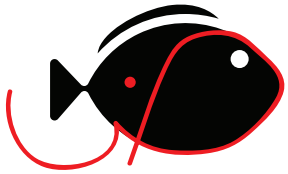
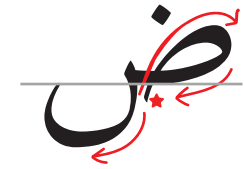
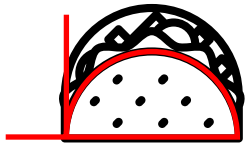
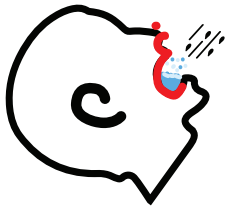
Writing Guidance

1 - Starting point 2 - Follow the arrow 3 - Writing line

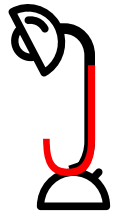
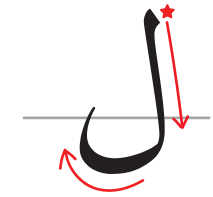
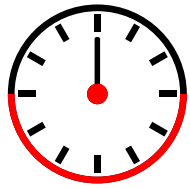
Visual Hint	Pronunciation		Name	Isolated Version
	This letter is a vowel and has three sounds: *A*rch d*a*d (long a) *A*lice (short a)	***ā***	***Alif***	
	One dot *b*elow; the *b*oat	***b***	***Baa'***	
	*T*wo dots on *t*op	***t***	***Taa'***	
	*Th*ree dots on top; *Th*ird eye	***th***	***Thaa'***	
	*J*ug	***j***	***Jeem***	
	It's like H, but it comes from a point deeper down in your throat, the same point used when clearing your throat. It's like the sound you make after you drink a cold drink.	***ḥ***	***Haa'***	
	Khkhkh snoring sound	***kh***	***Khaa'***	

Visual Hint	Pronunciation		Name	Isolated Version
	This *d*ude's nose	***d***	***Daal***	
	*Th*e bindi; *Th*is	***dh***	***Thaal***	
	*R*ib roll the 'r' like in Spanish	***r***	***Raa'***	
	*Z*ebra stripes	***z***	***Zayn'***	
	*S*aw, *S*ea	***s***	***Seen***	
	*Ch*andelier, *Sh*eet	***sh***	***Sheen***	
	A guttural version of the س It's similar to the sound of 's' in '*s*oup cup'.*	***ṣ***	***Saad***	

* There are no equivalent sounds in English.

Visual Hint	Pronunciation		Name	Isolated Version
	A guttural version of the د and sounds like d in '*D*ory'. *	ḍ	***Daad***	
	A guttural version of the ت and sounds like the t in '*t*aco' or '*T*om'. *	ṭ	***Taa***	
	A guttural version of the ذ and the 'th' in '*th*ose'. The animal in the picture is called *th*abi in Arabic. *	ẓ	***THaa***	
	The sound you make when the doctor checks your mouth with a popsicle stick; put your finger on the bottom of your throat, press down and say it. *	c	***A'ayn'***	
	Gargling sound *	gh	***Ghayn***	
	*F*an	f	***Faa***	
	A guttural version of the ك, sounds like q in '*q*uarter'; use the back of your tongue and throat. *	q	***Qhaaf***	

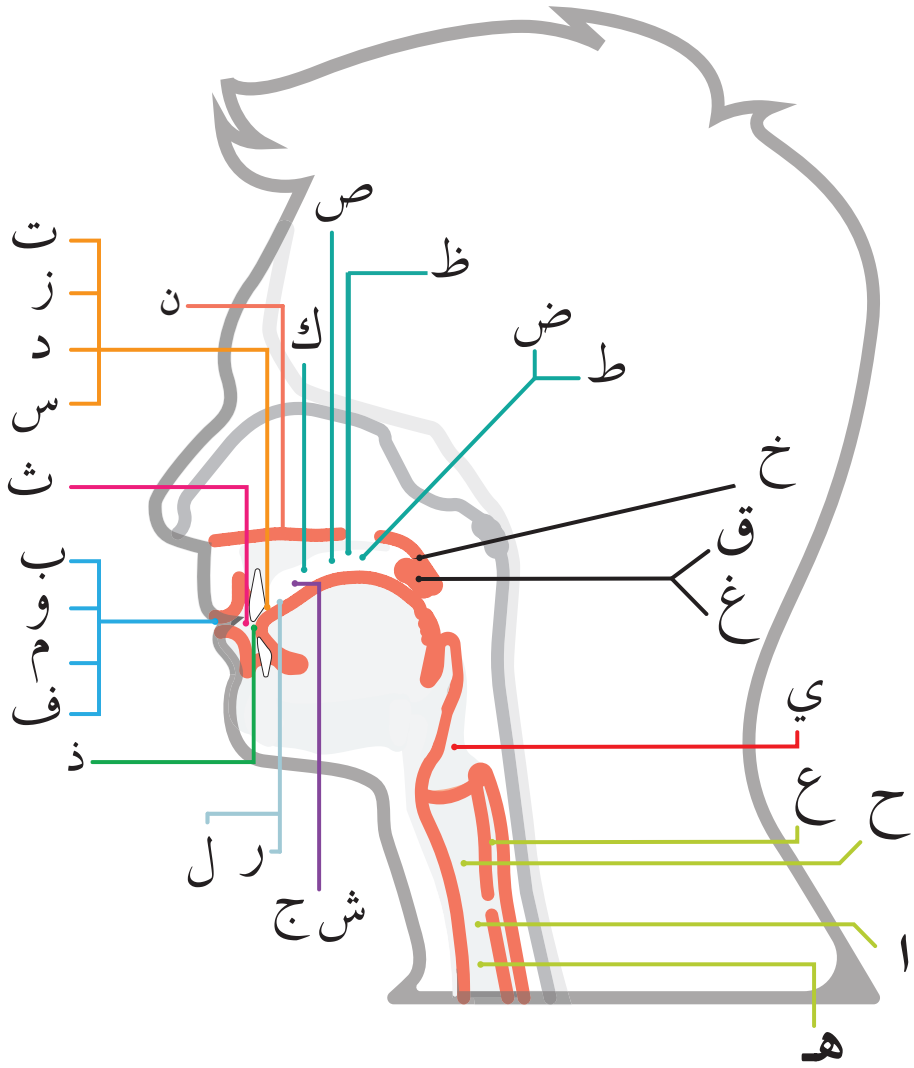
* There are no equivalent sounds in English.

Visual Hint	Pronunciation		Name	Isolated Version
	Cane, Key	***k***	***Kaaf***	
	Lamp	***l***	***Laam***	
	Moustache	***m***	***Meem***	
	One dot; Noon time	***n***	***Noon***	
	Soft H like in hole; the sound of a gentle breath.	***h***	***Haa***	
	This letter can be a vowel or a consonant and it has three sounds: Oo/Oh/Wa Moon More Wind	***w*** ***ū***	***Wow***	
	This letter can be a vowel or a consonant and it has three sounds: Ee/Ay/Ya Feed Tail Yellow Duck	***y*** ***ī***	***Yaa***	

Section 1.2

مَخارِج الحُروف
Vocal Exits and Pronunciations

As shown in Figure 1, the sound of every letter in the Arabic alphabet has a specific place from where it originates.



Key

Front
- lips
- tongue with teeth
- front top of mouth
- behind the teeth
- nose
- tongue vibrates in between the teeth
- tongue / roll the r

Middle
- soft palate
- uvula

Back
- top of the throat
- middle of the throat

Figure 1

Section 1.3

كِتابَة الحُروف
Writing the Alphabet

The Head and the Body

To write Arabic letters within words, it is helpful to consider each letter as having two parts: the head and the body.

■ Head
■ Body

ق س ر ب

Letter Positioning on the Line

A letter's position on the line depends on the shape of the letter. For letters that have a dipped curve, the 'body' (in this case also the dipped curve) is placed below the line, while the 'head' is placed above the line. Letters that do not have a dipped curve are written on the line.

ج د س ر غ ب

Forming Letters within Words

The form of a letter depends on whether it is at the beginning, middle or end of a word. To connect letters at the beginning and in the middle of a word, we only use the 'head' of the letter, and don't use the 'body'.

Here is an example showing the different positions of the letter س:

End (the last letter of the word): The entire letter (head and body) is connected with a 'hand' only on the right.

Middle (in the middle of the word): The head is connected with a 'hand' on both sides.

(except in the case of one-handed letters marked with a * in the following table)

Beginning (the first letter of the word): The head is connected with a 'hand' only on the left side.

One-armed letters are marked with a ✹ and are not connected to the left.

Pronunciation	End	Middle	Beginning	Isolated (with the 'head' circled)	
ā	ـا/ ـى broken Alif: 'Alif Maqsurah'	ـا	ا	ا	✹
b	ـب	ـبـ	بـ	ب	
t	ـت | ـة/ tight Ta: 'Ta-marbutta'	ـتـ	تـ	ت	
th	ـث	ـثـ	ثـ	ث	
j	ـج ـڿ	ـجـ ـڿـ	جـ	ج	
ḥ	ـح ـڂ	ـحـ ـڂـ	حـ	ح	
kh	ـخ ـڅ	ـخـ ـڅـ	خـ	خ	
d	ـد	ـد	د	د	✹
dh	ـذ	ـذ	ذ	ذ	✹
r	ـر	ـر	ر	ر	✹
z	ـز	ـز	ز	ز	✹
s	ـس	ـسـ	سـ	س	
sh	ـش	ـشـ	شـ	ش	
ṣ	ـص	ـصـ	صـ	ص	

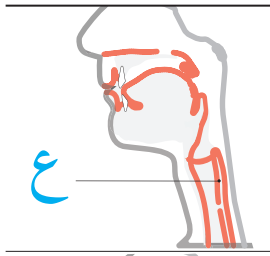
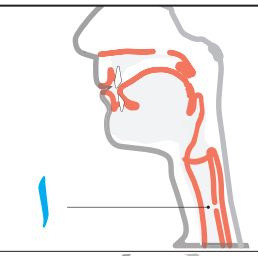
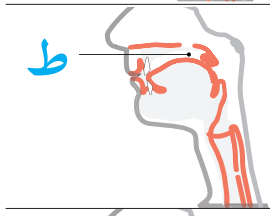
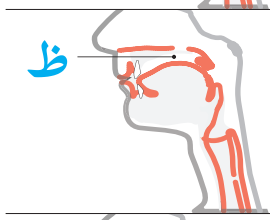
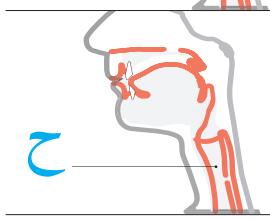
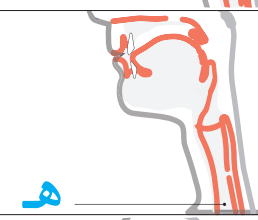
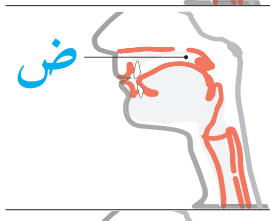
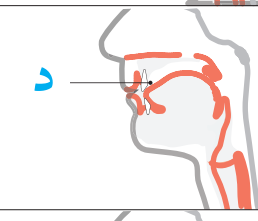
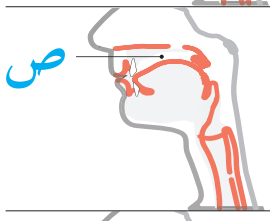
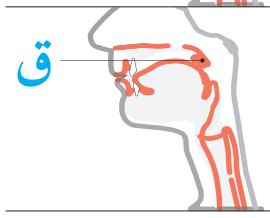
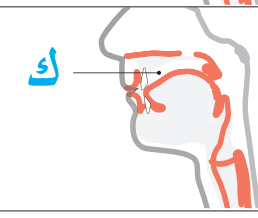
Pronunciation	End	Middle	Beginning	Isolated (with the 'head' circled)	
ḍ	ـض	ـضـ	ضـ	ض	
ṭ	ـط	ـطـ	طـ	ط	
ẓ	ـظ	ـظـ	ظـ	ظ	
c	ـع	ـعـ	عـ	ع	
gh	ـغ	ـغـ	غـ	غ	
f	ـف	ـفـ	فـ	ف	
q	ـق	ـقـ	قـ	ق	
k	ـك	ـكـ	كـ	ك ى : is the head	
l	ـل	ـلـ	لـ	ل	
m	ـم	ـمـ	مـ	م	
n	ـن	ـنـ	نـ	ن	
h	ـه	ـهـ ـھـ	هـ	ه	
w ū	ـو	ـو	و	و	*
y ī	ـي	ـيـ	يـ	ي	

Note 1: In informal Arabic handwriting, the dots which make up some letters (e.g. ت) can be replaced with a line for two dots (e.g. ت = ت) and with a circumflex for three dots (e.g. ث = ث).

Note 2: The 'head part' of the letters س and ش can be replaced with a line in Arabic handwriting (e.g.س).

Letters that have similar sounds:

The table below illustrates the vocal exits for a selection of Arabic alphabet letters which students regularly have difficulty pronouncing or identifying. Each row shows two similar letters which can be difficult for learners to differentiate between.

Letter Exit	Pronunciation	Strong Letters	Letter Exit	Pronunciation	Soft Letters
	***a'h*** The sound you make when the a doctor checks your mouth with a tongue depressor.	ع		***ah*** This letter is a vowel and has three sounds: *A*rch d*a*d *A*lice	ا
	***Tah*** A guttural version of the ت and sounds like *t* in '*t*aco' or "*T*om".	ط		***tah*** Like the *T* in *T*wo.	ت
	***Thah*** A guttural version of the ذ and uses the back of the tongue like the ظ in *th*ose.	ظ		***the*** Like the *Th* in *Th*e.	ذ
	***Ha*** The sound you make when clearing your throat.	ح		***ha*** Soft *h* like in *h*ole; The sound of a gentle breath.	ه
	***Dah*** A guttural version of the د and sounds like *d* in '*D*ory'.	ض		***dah*** Like the *d* in *d*ude.	د
	***Sah*** A guttural version of the س and sounds like *s* in '*s*oup cup'.	ص		***sah*** Like the *s* in *s*aw.	س
	***Qah*** Stronger version of ك, sounds like *q* in '*q*uarter'.	ق		***kah*** Like the *k* in *k*ey.	ك

The pronunciation of some Arabic letters within the Levant region depends on a person's accent. See the possible pronunciations for the following letters in the table below:

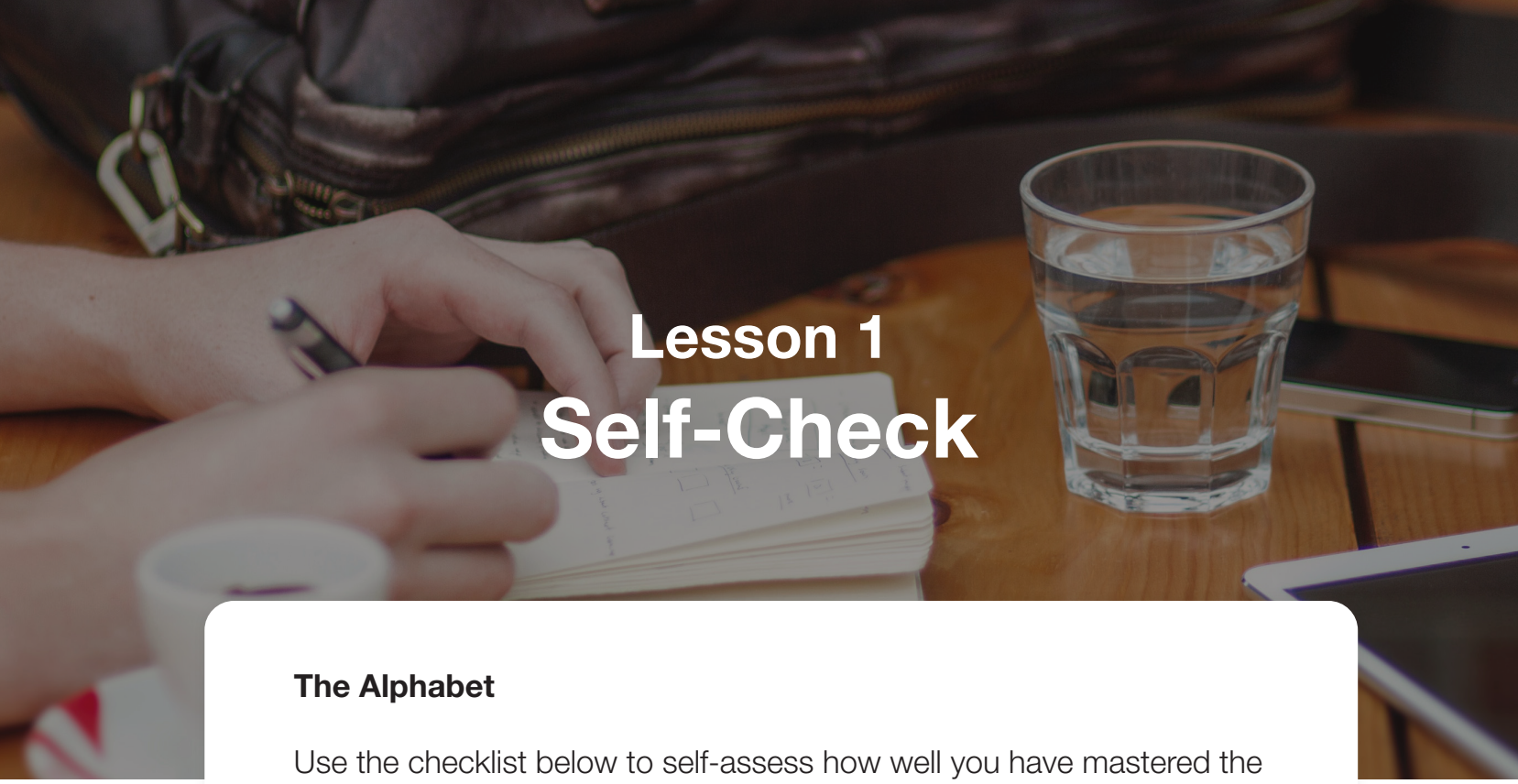
Other Possible Sounds	Original Sound	Letter
t / s t sound is more used than s	thah	ث ثالِث
the sound of j in bonjour	jah	ج جَبَل
d / z	the	ذ ذيب
d / z	***Th***ah	ظ ظَبي
k / a / the sound of the g in Gun	***Q***ah	ق قَمَر

Note: It is highly recommended to listen to the audio to hear the correct sound.

Section 1.4

سُلَّم الكَلِمات لِلدَّرس الأَوَّل
Ladder of Words for Lesson 1

التَّرْجَمِة **Translation**	حَرفيّاً **Transliteration**	الكِلمِة **Word**
bye Literally “peace”	salam	سَلام
excellent / great	mumtaz	مُمتاز
hello / hi	marHabaa	مَرحَبا
hello / welcome Literally “two hellos”	marHabtain	مَرْحَبْتَيْن Response to marHabaa
How are you? *(masc. / fem.)*	keefak / keefik	كِيفَك / كِيفِك؟
I want / need I don’t want / need	biDy maa biDy	بِدّي ما بِدّي
no	la’	لَأ
thank you	shukran	شُكراً
yes	ah	اه
you're welcome / pardon / excuse me	‘afwan	عَفْواً



Lesson 1
Self-Check

The Alphabet

Use the checklist below to self-assess how well you have mastered the topics in this lesson. For any topic below 5 stars, refer to the relevant section for review.

A) I can read the letters of the alphabet.	☆☆☆★★ Section 1.1
B) I can use Deewan Institute's memorisation techniques to associate letters with pictures and sounds.	☆☆☆★★ Section 1.1
C) I can pronounce each letter, and I know its vocal positions.	☆☆☆★★ Section 1.2
D) I can write the alphabet, including each letter's beginning, middle, and end position.	☆☆☆★★ Section 1.3
E) I am familiar with all of the vocabulary in "The Ladder of Words" for Lesson 1.	☆☆☆★★ Section1.4

Lesson 2

Vowels and Word Building (Sukoon and Shaddeh)

In this lesson you will learn:

A) Long and short vowels. Section 2.1

B) The different sounds associated with long and short vowels. Section 2.1

C) The position of the short vowels: FatHa (َ), Dammeh (ُ), and Kasrah (ِ). Section 2.1

D) How to pronounce simple Arabic words that contain short and long vowels. Section 2.1

E) About the Sukoon (ْ) and Shaddeh (ّ). Section 2.2

F) The different sounds associated with the Sukoon (ْ) and Shaddeh (ّ). Section 2.2

G) To form words using letters, vowels, Sukoon (ْ) and Shaddeh (ّ). Section 2.2, 2.3

H) Word building using the different forms of each letter and the short vowels. Section 2.3

I) How to build your vocabulary using the "Ladder of Words" for Lesson 2. Section 2.4

To access the audio files for this lesson, scan the QR code.
This will take you to a YouTube channel where you can listen to the audio files directly.

If you experience any issues, please contact:
management@deewaninstitute.com

SCAN ME

Section 2.1

مُقَدِّمة لحُروف العِلّة والحَرَكات
Introduction to The Vowels

There are six vowels (three long and three short) in Arabic.

Long Vowels

A. The long vowels are the letters ا , و , ي when they appear in the middle or the end of the word.

B. When they appear in the beginning of the word, they are consonants.

C. Long vowels are held for about a second when you say them.

Long vowels have two possible sounds as shown in the table below:

IJMES	English Equivalent Sounds	Translation	Transliteration	Examples	Vowels
ā	far	mouse	faar	فار	ا
	can	door	baab	باب	
ū	poor	light	noor	نور	و
	bone	colour	loan	لون	
ī	keep	Eid	‘Eid	عيد	ي
	late	home	bate	بيت	

Short Vowels

A. The short vowels are called Harakaat, which literally means ‘movements’.

B. Each of the short vowels has two possible sounds, just like the long vowels.

C. The short vowels make the same sounds as the long vowels, but are held for ¼ of a second when they are pronounced, as seen in the table below:

Derived From	English Equivalent Sound	IJMES	The Short Vowel
ا	but at	a	FatHa فَتحَة ◌َ
و	full to	u	Dammeh ضَمّة ◌ُ
ي	if bed	i	Kasrah كَسْرَة ◌ِ

Long and Short Vowels: A Comparison

Transliteration	With a Letter	The Long Vowel	Transliteration	With a Letter	The Short Vowel
baa	با	ا	ba	بَ	◌َ
qoo	قو	و	qu	قُ	◌ُ
see	سي	ي	si (as in sit)	سِ	◌ِ

The meaning of a word can be very different depending on whether a long or short vowel is used, as seen in the examples below:

Long Vowel			Short Vowel		
Translation	**Transliteration**	**Word**	**Translation**	**Transliteration**	**Word**
he went	raaH	راح	will	raH	رَح
hava beans	fool	فول	jasmine	ful	فُل
who	mean	مين	from	min	مِن

Note: Long vowels become consonants whenthey come in the beginning of the word or when short vowel are used with them.

Vowels As Consonants

as a consonant				as a vowels			
Translation	**Transliteration**	**Word**	**Letter**	**Translation**	**Transliteration**	**Word**	**Letter**
me / I / I'm	ana	انا	ا	peace	salam	سَلام	ا
boy / son	walad	وَلد	و	banana	moze	موز	و
let's go / come on	yalla	يَلّا	ي	house	bate	بيت	ي

Section 2.2

السُّكون
The Sukoon

Sukoon is a small circular symbol placed above the letter indicating the absence of a vowel. Since it indicates the lack of a vowel, it is often not written.

The Sukoon (ْ)

Translation	Transliteration	Word
but / only / enough / stop	bas	بَسْ
every / all	kul	كُلْ
from	min	مِنْ

Some words can be pronounced differently depending on a person's accent. Sometimes a letter can take a Sukoon and other times the same letter can take one of the Harakaat.

Differences in Accents

With Sukoon				With Harakaat			
Translation	Transliteration	Word	Letter	Translation	Transliteration	Word	Letter
girl	bint	بِنْت	نْ	girl	binit	بِنِت	نِ
after	ba'd	بَعْد	عْ	after	ba'id	بَعِد	عِ
I arrived	wisilt	وصِلْت	لْ	I arrived	wisilit	وصِلِت	لِ

الشَّدّة
The Shaddeh

Shaddeh is a w-shaped symbol placed above a consonant to indicate the letter is doubled. In effect, it doubles the sound of the letter by lengthening it.

With Shaddeh			Without Shaddeh		
Translation	**Transliteration**	**Word**	**Translation**	**Transliteration**	**Word**
bathroom / toilet / bath / shower	hammaam	حَمّام	doves / pigeons	hamaam	حَمام
he smashed / shattered	kassar	كَسَّر	he broke	kasar	كَسَر
he changed	ghayyar	غَيَّر	other	gheir	غير

Tanween is 'nunation' in English and it is used in classical Arabic to distinguish nouns from other parts of speech by doubling short vowels (FatHa, Dammeh, or Kasrah).
The only type of Tanween used in Levantine Arabic is Tanween el-FatHa, which adds a doubled FatHa to the last letter of the word and is pronounced like 'an'. See the examples in the table below:

Translation	Transliteration	Words with Tanween el-FatHa
thank you	shukran	شُكراً
you're welcome / pardon me /excuse me	'afwan	عَفواً
you're welcome	ahlan	أَهلاً
sometimes	ahyanan	أحياناً
usually	'aadatan	عادةً

Section 2.3

تَكوين الكِلمِة
Word Building

Commonly Used Words and Phrases During class.

نِهايَة End	وَسَط Middle	بِدايَة Beginning	مُنفَصِل Isolated
ـا/ـى	ـا	ا	ا
لا no / not	صاحِب friend (male) / boyfriend / owner (i.e. landlord / storeowner)	اَنا I / me	one-armed letter
ـب	ـبـ	بـ	ب
بَحِب I love / I like	شَباب guys / young people / youth	بَحكي I speak	connects to both sides
ـت/ـة/ـة	ـتـ	تـ	ت
اِستِراحَة break / rest	كتاب book	تَعبان tired	connects to both sides
ـث	ـثـ	ثـ	ث
ثَلاث three	مِثال example	ثنين two	connects to both sides
ـج	ـجـ	جـ	ج
جاج chicken	واجِب homework / duty	جاهِز ready	connects to both sides
ـح	ـحـ	حـ	ح
صَح correct / right	صَفحَة page	حَرف letter	connects to both sides